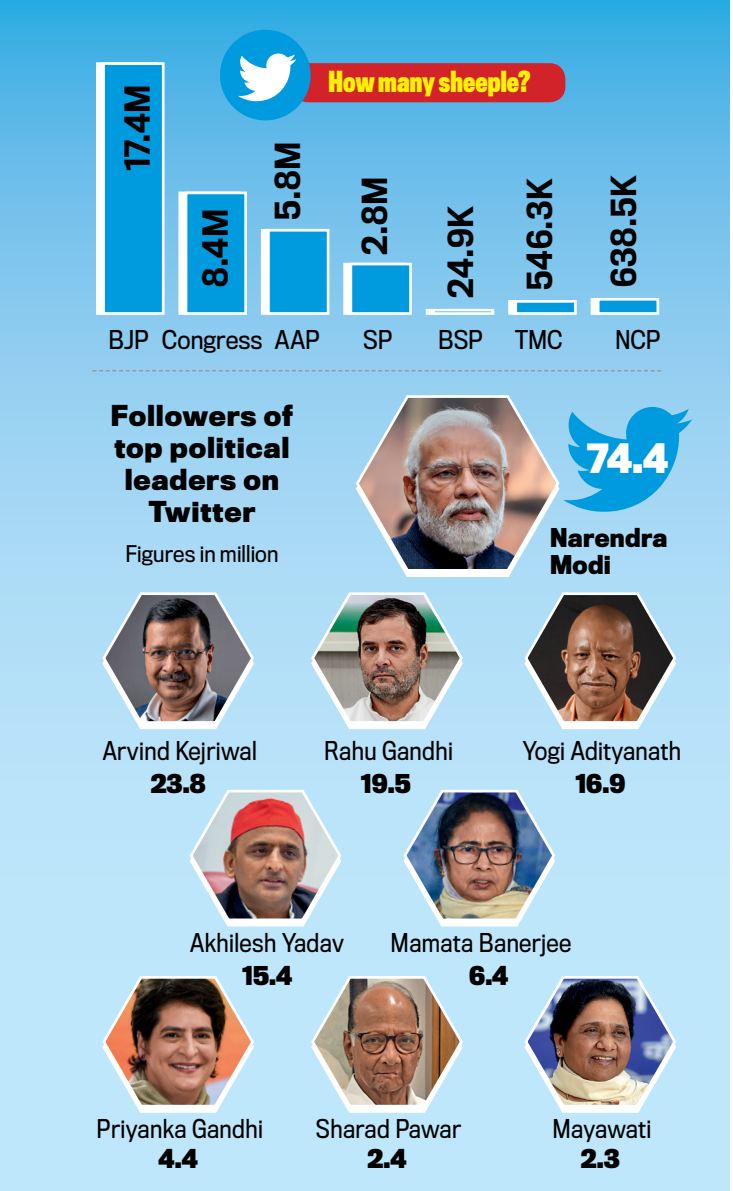


Graphic by ASIT ROY

crafted its campaign as a riposte to the ruling BJP's '*CM da haisi* (Let's talk to the CM)' initiative, where anyone can directly connect with the CM through a helpline and share their grievances. Its counter platform, tagged '*Sarkar taribra?* (Is the govt listening?)', invites reports from the public on the actual record on the ground. Social media platforms are awash with the message that there's no accountability or transparency—an official YouTube channel will soon join the chorus.

SP: SAIFAI HI-FI

Akhilesh Yadav will no longer be able to showcase those milling crowds, and there's a sense of being caught off-guard when it comes to the Samajwadis. The online campaign being cooked up by the war room at Janeshwar Mishra Trust, just behind the party HQ in Lucknow, has a mix of new dishes and food from the fridge, reheated for a quick meal. Again, the focus will be on live-streaming digital rallies—with Akhilesh and other star campaigners plying their new-age socialist politics in demat form. "We have created WhatsApp groups for all 403 assembly seats," says a partyman. "We will provide a link whenever a live event happens. We are creating WhatsApp groups at the block level too, so that the links keep getting forwarded."

A 'Samajwadi Digital Force' of SP volunteers had been set up in 2017, but it went inactive after the Lok Sabha polls. It's now being reactivated. A brand-new Twitter handle, an FB page and several WhatsApp groups have now been created under this name. The '*Kaam bolta hai*' campaign, again of 2017 vintage, is being revived too—it focuses on work done under Akhilesh's stewardship of the UP government. Besides, new social media accounts are being floated, as are new FB pages with names like '*Baees mein bicycle*'. Sources also reveal that the party will seek to engage local YouTubers in the districts, especially those of an anti-BJP or pro-socialist mindset.

BSP: THE 'E-LEPHANT'

For a pyramidical party built around a strong connect between a totemic figure at the top and a solid base, a 'Mayawati rally' used to be quite an event. This event will now go virtual. The BSP supremo plans to address 75 e-rallies—one for every district—so the necessary set-up is coming up at her Mall Avenue residence in Lucknow. The party's IT cell, also operating out of the state capital, has two teams: one at the local HQ, another at general secretary Satish Mishra's office. Twitter accounts, FB pages and the official handles of party leaders will broadcast Mayawati's speeches. Again, the BSP plans to enlist local YouTubers of an Ambedkarite persuasion across districts.

DOWNLOADING AAP

Outside of the BJP, the Aam Aadmi Party perhaps swims the best in digital waters. An online-only campaign will hardly perturb them, creatures of the social media as they are. In Punjab, AAP is going full-on with old videos of its comedian-leader, Bhagwant Mann, taking digs at conventional politicians. His speeches are being live-streamed on FB and other e-platforms. A crack social media team of 75-odd people backs him with stinging spoofs on other parties. Simultaneously, it's pushing the slogan '*Ek Mauka Kejriwal Nu*'. Any number of Arvind Kejriwal's speeches are up on these channels—in short, it's a beehive of activity. The fact that Punjab has 84.32 internet subscribers per 100 people—perhaps the densest in the country—redounds to the advantage of newer parties.

TMC VS 'GHAJINI'

No digital slouches, going into online mode won't harm the Trinamool's foray into the Konkan. Derided as a 'tourist party', and finding its own 'outsider' jibe flung back at it, the TMC's digital loudspeakers are focused on giving it back in good measure, with vocabulary worthy of online trolls. Describing CM Pramod Sawant as a 'Ghajini', a reference to his amnesia when it comes to promises, the TMC has been offering politics-fatigued Goans visions of a new dawn. Its anthem, '*Don fulancho kaal, Goenchi navi sakaal* (Time for two flowers, new dawn for Goa)', hits the ether soon. ■